The trend is even more pronounced in the digital space. Of the women who had faced some form of online abuse, 42 per cent reported blocking the person and 27 per cent said they reported the matter to the platform if it was a serious offence. The results also reveal that education and economic empowerment play a positive role in women's ability to understand and voice consent or the lack of it.

Unfortunately, the response from those occupying public spaces is not forthcoming. As many as 57 per cent of respondents stated that people who witness any form of unwanted sexual behaviour against women would be unlikely to help or intervene. In public spaces, which include public transport, it is very difficult to identify or pin down abusers because of the large crowds. This also makes it difficult to report violations and so support from bystanders and the public becomes a crucial social mechanism to control sexual harassment.

The survey's results on consent and sexual behaviour in the workplace reveal a worrying reality. Only 44 per cent of women felt they could refuse an uncomfortable request, while the majority feared job consequences if they refused. A whopping 36 per cent stated that their boss or manager proceeded with late-night meetings, personal messages or "special attention" despite their voicing discomfort or refusal.



TEACHING YOUNG WOMEN ABOUT CONSENT IS NOT ENOUGH IF IT IS NOT ACCOMPANIED BY GIVING THEM CONFIDENCE IN THEIR VOICE

Here again, the responses are encouraging. Only 3 per cent said they would do nothing about it. While 15 per cent said they would report it to HR, the others stated they would either confront it directly or deal with it in more subtle ways. Clearly, women have an increased understanding of their rights, but institutions and the individuals within them need more accountability.

Young women in the 18-25 age group showed a high understanding of the concept of consent, but this did not translate into a greater sense of autonomy. We find that young women are the most vulnerable to sexual violations, within and outside the home. Teaching them about consent is not enough if it is not accompanied by giving them confidence in their voice. Most remember their first, or first few, experiences of sexual harassment as moments of shame and an inability to respond, even though they knew it was a violation.

This is why visibility matters. I am heartened by a recent campaign carried out by young women in Ajmer called 'Main Bhi Bahar Jaungi', in which they held a night rally in autorickshaws. The mere fact of their presence in public spaces at night brought a new narrative. Claiming the night is itself an assertion that the city belongs to them too.

I have been engaging with women's safety and freedom in public spaces for over two decades, and I see hope. While sexual harassment is a reality in both physical and digital spaces, women are not retreating. They are claiming their space, asserting their right to take risks and make their own choices. Unfortunately, our social and cultural narratives and institutions have not kept pace.

The tired rhetoric of identifying women as daughters, sisters, wives and mothers needs to be discarded. We have to turn the problem on its head, as another slogan exemplifies: 'Stop asking what she was wearing. Start asking why he felt entitled'. ■

The author is co-founder & CEO, Safetipin, which uses crowd-sourced data to make cities safer and more inclusive for women